were threatened by the Taiping's collectivist intentions. This was one of the most violent wars in Chinese history, ravaging much of the country and its economy too. It also led to the weakening of central authority and the birth of powerful local satraps. This would eventually lead to the phenomenon of 'warlordism' during the early years of a weak republic.

While there were other local rebellions in several parts of the country, it is the Taiping rebellion which severely weakened the state, making it more vulnerable to the ensuing external threats. With a peculiar mix of Christian and Chinese millenarian beliefs, such as the supposed invulnerability of the Taiping warriors to bullets and cannon, the Taiping rebellion had a nativist dimension, attacking the Manchus as alien oppressors.

The long reign of the emperor Qianlong (1736–99) witnessed a period of important economic changes. China's population saw a great surge, from about 178 million in 1749 to 359 million in 1811 and 432 million in 1851.There was intense pressure on land as a result of the rising population, even though the new crops from the Americas such as maize, groundnut, sweet potato and new high-yield varieties of rice from South and South-East Asia also increased food supply dramatically. The cultivation of tobacco and cotton as cash crops also expanded. Though the Manchus had tried to keep the vast area of north-east China closed to Han migration and reserve the pastureland for their own kin, this could not be sustained. Much of the area of Manchuria and Mongolia experienced large-scale settlement by Han migrants. This also happened in the more sparsely populated areas of western and south-western China. This spatial spread of the Han population to the non-Han territories of the Qing empire would create a more expansive Han nationalism when the empire came to an end.

Qianlong's reign was also a period when China began to participate in a broader network of maritime trade. The Qing had continued the Ming dynasty prohibition on foreign trade, but this was lifted in 1685. The conquest of Taiwan in 1683 also played a role in the restoration of foreign trade as the island was already a part of the regional trade network linking South-East Asia and Japan, where increasingly, European commercial entities were beginning to muscle in. Taiwan was colonized by the Dutch in